brushed off as an inconsequential player, but 2022 showed it can damage the Congress by pooling in fence-sitting votes," he adds.

HIS FIRST TEST

Whether Chavda can stanch that will be tested in the next round of urban body elections in early 2026, where 16 out Gujarat's 17 municipal corporations—among the highest pools in India—and 81 out of 149 municipalities will be up for grabs. As of now, the BJP controls 148 municipalities; the Congress has one—Salaya, in Jamnagar. Saffron dominance over corporations, too, is near-complete, with outright control over nine.

Takeaways

- **Five-term MLA Amit Chavda is chosen as the Gujarat Congress chief**
- **An OBC face known for ideological loyalty, he has to cleanse the party rolls**
- **His challenge is to lift the party from the acute depression it has sunk into**

This is a significant part of the state's political landscape, for Gujarat has a high urban density. At least 52 of its 182 assembly seats are considered 'urban'; the Congress won just three of those in 2022. The urban middle class is clearly its Achilles' heel. The party has not sorted out its outreach to this segment—its 'soft Hindutva' me-tooism, which saw Rahul visiting dozens of temples ahead of the 2017 election, won few converts. An Anand native like Chavda focusing instead on the state's urban decay, in a bottom-up narrative, could be a good start. ■

▶ TAMIL NADU

DEGREES OF PARALYSIS

Tamil Nadu's higher education stays stuck in a limbo while the state-governor legal turf battle drags on

By **Kavitha Muralidharan**

ON THE SPRAWLING campus of the University of Madras (UnoM), the silence of enforced inertia is hard to miss. Professors have to go out and queue up at Chennai's government departments to get salaries and promotions cleared. PhD theses await signatures that never come. Files gather dust. It's a picture replicated across Tamil Nadu's public universities—from Anna University down the road, to Bharathiar University in Coimbatore and Madurai Kamaraj University (MKU) in the south.

As many as 12 of the state's 22 public universities have been functioning without regular vice-chancellors (V-Cs) for over two years now, some for even longer. Not due to a lack of worthy candidates, or of funds. Blame it, instead, on a constitutional impasse. In less abstract terms, a bitter turf battle for control over universities between the state government and the governor that has become a big strand in debates around federalism.

THE FEDERAL QUESTION

R.N. Ravi, who took the gubernatorial office in 2021, has since impaled himself in a series of confrontations with M.K. Stalin's DMK regime. While mirroring the pattern in other Opposition-ruled states that brought the Governor's role under sharp political scrutiny, Tamil Nadu differed in how prolonged the stalemate became—and the knotty legal imbroglio it spawned.

The dysfunction had become so marked that even the Supreme Court raised an eyebrow at the occlusionary pattern in Ravi's actions—or inactions. While the issue awaits a judicial solution, higher education stays in a state of paralysis in one of India's most academically advanced states, with its schools and universities performing consistently well in education indices.

TECHNICAL KNOCKOUT

In Tamil Nadu, the right to appoint V-Cs is vested in the governor, in their capacity as chancellor, and they are meant to act on a search committee's recommendations. Like the AIADMK before it, the DMK regime sought to change this status quo. Provocation: Ravi sat on a series of names finalised by search committees, sometimes demanding a central nominee on those committees. The state insisted on its autonomy in the matter.

At any rate, between 2020 and 2023, the state assembly passed 10 bills to effectively transfer the power to appoint V-Cs to the CM, removing the governor's nominee from the committees. "It's demo-